

Gamebirds

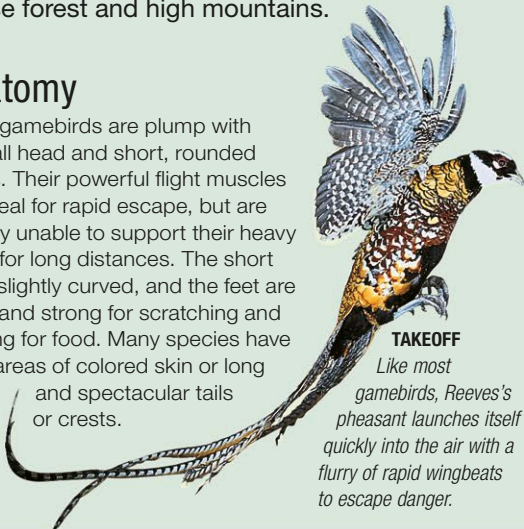
PHYLUM	Chordata
CLASS	Aves
ORDER	Galliformes
FAMILIES	5
SPECIES	299

This group of mainly ground-dwelling species includes some of the birds most useful to humans. In their domestic forms (including the chicken), they provide an important food source, and many other species (such as pheasants, partridges, and grouse) are hunted for sport or food.

Also in this group are the spectacular curassows and the less conspicuous guineafowl and megapodes. Gamebirds are found almost worldwide (even within the Arctic Circle) in a wide range of habitats, including dense forest and high mountains.

Anatomy

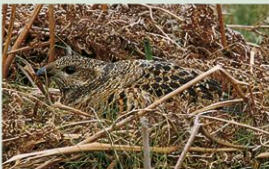
Most gamebirds are plump with a small head and short, rounded wings. Their powerful flight muscles are ideal for rapid escape, but are usually unable to support their heavy body for long distances. The short bill is slightly curved, and the feet are stout and strong for scratching and digging for food. Many species have bare areas of colored skin or long and spectacular tails or crests.



TAKEOFF
Like most gamebirds, Reeves's pheasant launches itself quickly into the air with a flurry of rapid wingbeats to escape danger.

DISPLAY

This is the display of the Palawan peacock-pheasant. The "eyes" on the fan are thought to attract the female.



CAMOUFLAGE
Ground-dwellers, like this female black grouse, need cryptic plumage to avoid detection. Another grouse species, the ptarmigan, changes color with the seasons.

Reproduction

Most gamebirds nest in a shallow depression in the ground. Megapodes are unusual in that, instead of incubating their eggs, they store them in mounds or burrows, allowing the sun's heat, microbial activity, or geothermal energy to keep them warm. Young gamebirds fly very soon after hatching—often within a week or, in the case of megapodes, within a few hours.



CLUTCH SIZE
Compared with other birds, many gamebirds lay large clutches. Some produce up to 20 eggs (a pheasant's eggs are shown here).

Leipoa ocellata

Malleefowl



Location W. and S. Australia

Length	24 in (61 cm)
Weight	4½ lb (2 kg)
Plumage	Sexes alike
Migration	Nonmigrant
Status	Vulnerable



The malleefowl and its close relatives—known as megapodes—are the only birds that do not directly incubate their eggs. Instead, eggs are laid in



a giant heap of leaves, sticks, and bark, up to 5 ft (1.5 m) high and 15 ft (4.5 m) across, and the heat given off as this decomposes incubates the eggs. During the lengthy incubation period, lasting up to 11 weeks, the parents stay close to the mound and monitor its temperature with their bills. If it gets too hot, they take some of the vegetation away; if too cool, they add more to it. When the young hatch, they dig their way out—fully feathered and able to look after themselves. Male and female malleefowl form pairs that last for years; they live fairly separately much of the time, but come closer together during the summer breeding season. The malleefowl lives on a largely vegetarian diet consisting of fruit, buds, and seeds; however, it will also eat invertebrates such as ants, beetles, spiders, and cockroaches.

Ortalis motmot

Little chachalaca

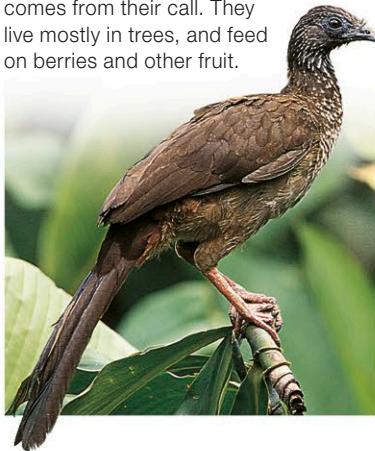


Location N. South America

Length	15 in (38 cm)
Weight	21 oz (600 g)
Plumage	Sexes alike
Migration	Nonmigrant
Status	Least concern



This species is the smallest member of the Cracidae—a family of gamebirds from the Americas that also includes the curassows. Compared to these, chachalacas are slim-bodied and plain in color, and they do not have crests. There are about 16 species and they are all noisy birds—their name comes from their call. They live mostly in trees, and feed on berries and other fruit.



Crax daubentoni

Yellow-knobbed curassow



Location N. South America

Length	35 in (90 cm)
Weight	Not recorded
Plumage	Sexes alike
Migration	Nonmigrant
Status	Near threatened



Like other curassows, this large forest bird feeds mainly on the ground, but it flies up into trees if threatened. Its most striking features are its crest, made of feathers that curl forward, and the fleshy yellow knob at the base of its bill. It eats fruit, leaves, seeds, and small animals. Unusually for gamebirds, curassows nest off the ground, with both sexes helping in the construction. The female lays just 2 eggs—a tiny clutch compared to those of many ground-nesting gamebirds.